after being accused of Communist sympathies during the McCarthy era of the 1950s. By 1963, it was a question of not if, but when, China would test its atomic bomb.

The Government of India was also preparing for this day. In August 1963, Homi Bhabha, the chairman of India's Atomic Energy Commission, had offered advice to Prime Minister Nehru on what India should do in the light of the psychological and political impact that a Chinese nuclear test might have in terms of the balance of power in Asia. Bhabha correctly assessed that such a test may not pose an immediate military threat to India, but the psychological fallout could be catastrophic for a nation that was still reeling from the aftermath of a border war with China in 1962. Bhabha wrote: 'I am inclined to the view that the only way this can be done at present is for us to show that, should China explode such a device, we are in a position to do so within a few months thereafter.' [3] From the very beginning, China was an important consideration in our nuclear calculations.

The first Chinese nuclear test was conducted at Lop Nor on 16 October 1964. Chinese Premier Zhou Enlai wrote to heads of state and government, including Prime Minister Lal Bahadur Shastri (Nehru had passed away in May 1964). As might be expected, the letter contained China's justification for the nuclear test, which Premier Zhou said China was 'compelled' to conduct in order to protect the Chinese people from the US nuclear threat. Zhou's letter also contained a proposal to convene an international conference to 'reach an agreement to the effect the nuclear powers and those countries which may soon become nuclear powers undertake not to use nuclear weapons . . .' [4] It was an interesting formulation, that hinted at the possibility that they knew that India might also have been developing such capabilities. If this was an attempt to build a common front in the Third World, then India either missed the